

Chapter 61: I'm Here

Her soft arm applied gentle pressure, and her fragrant breath fell by Ning Fuyi's ear as the two faced each other and embraced tightly.

This time it was right. The thing outside no longer knocked on the stone coffin, and the sound of iron chains moved clattering to other stone coffins - it should be checking on the other "couples."

The two of them also relaxed somewhat from their initial tense bodies. However, once they relaxed, each other's scent and warmth came rushing forward, and who knows whose heartbeat was pounding wildly.

In this position, Chu Qingqiu was completely holding Ning Fuyi in her embrace. Ning Fuyi's hands felt awkward, not knowing where to place them. Putting them on Chu Qingqiu's waist wasn't appropriate, and keeping them between their chests...

Was even less appropriate.

She finally settled them on Chu Qingqiu's slender waist. The moment her hands landed, the body pressed tightly against her trembled slightly.

Ning Fuyi closed her eyes, trying to make her heartbeat less frantic, because she was already feeling suffocated.

Though Chu Qingqiu was slender, she still had the softness and curves of a mature woman, making one afraid to move at all.

Chu Qingqiu across from her wasn't much better off. Although they had made contact before on Zhaoyao Mountain, at that time Ning Fuyi still had a girl's flat figure and was short. Even when they were close, it didn't stir up too many emotions. But now the young woman had begun to show her feminine charm, her flesh and bones much softer and more proportioned.

Just a gentle embrace was enough to make one's hands and feet go numb.

The two of them embracing face to face like this was truly awkward, so Ning Fuyi spoke softly, trying to ease the embarrassing atmosphere.

"Venerable, where has it gone?" Ning Fuyi asked.

"It's checking the last coffin." Chu Qingqiu answered, her exhaled breath brushing against her ear, tickling and tingling.

"That's great." Ning Fuyi secretly shrank further into Chu Qingqiu's embrace, avoiding the airflow from her speech to prevent goosebumps from breaking out all over her body.

Actually, Chu Qingqiu was quite gentle at this moment, Ning Fuyi thought to herself, not as rigid as usual.

The two were silent for a while before Chu Qingqiu spoke: "I can hear it."

This damned mental communication - once Ning Fuyi lost control, it became public knowledge.

"I'm sweating a little..." Ning Fuyi tried to change the subject, hoping Chu Qingqiu would forget her previous words. But as soon as she finished speaking, a warm, dry hand landed on her forehead, gently dabbing.

Now Ning Fuyi was really sweating.

Fortunately, the sound of iron chains returned at this moment. The two held their breath again, alertly listening to the clattering sound stop beside their coffin.

The feeling of an unknown thing stopping right by one's ear was hair-raising. Ning Fuyi inconspicuously gripped her divine sword.

However, it didn't open the coffin. Instead, it slowly crouched down, and then came small sounds, like carefully chewing and swallowing something.

It was eating the corpses on the ground. Ning Fuyi immediately felt a chill, nauseated to the point where her scalp tingled. She used the light coming through the cracks to look at Chu Qingqiu, only to find that she was tightly closing her eyes, lost in thought.

Even without seeing it, the sound of human corpses being devoured with relish was indescribable, especially the sound of small bites crushing bones, making one's hands and feet go weak involuntarily.

Fortunately they had hidden in the coffin, or they would probably be the ones being eaten.

For a full incense stick's worth of time, that thing finally ate and drank its fill, got up again, and slowly left dragging its chains. The gong sounded one last time, and then outside was deathly silent.

However, just as Ning Fuyi was about to get up to investigate the situation, the stone coffin beneath them suddenly began to move. Ning Fuyi was held down by Chu Qingqiu, who said softly: "The mechanism is operating. Wait a bit longer."

The stone coffin shook and rattled, and for a moment the entire tomb was filled with the rumbling sound of stone scraping against the ground, so loud it made one's eyes see stars. After who knows how long, the coffin beneath them came to an abrupt stop with no more movement.

The two lay in the stone coffin, warm breath flowing between them, and for a moment they almost didn't want to get up.

It wasn't until Qiu Yi's somewhat resentful voice came through their minds: "Master, my hands are numb from being tied."

Only then did they wake up as if from a dream. They simultaneously reached out their hands and together pushed open the coffin lid. Cool wind poured into the coffin, blowing away the heated atmosphere in their minds.

Beneath their feet was no longer the previous tomb chamber, but a square space. Up, down, and all around were transparent, allowing them to see the faint starlight outside through the walls.

Ning Fuyi walked to the edge of the tomb chamber and reached out to touch it. Her fingertips felt cold, and she was surprised to discover that the so-called walls were actually thick water.

However, when her fingertips went in halfway, the water beside them seemed to become sticky, desperately pulling at her skin, and she couldn't push in any further.

The moment the two came out, the coffin that had carried them disappeared. The ground was clear, and stepping on it created ripples like on water.

In the center of the tomb chamber rose a square platform with black and white chess pieces placed on it - an unfinished game.

If Ning Fuyi could still handle the previous challenges somewhat, now she was completely stumped. She knew nothing about playing chess.

"Venerable, do you know how to play chess?" Ning Fuyi turned back to ask Chu Qingqiu. The other glanced at her, clasped her hands behind her back, and slowly sat down.

Her fingertips picked up a white piece from the side and gently placed it on the board. Then the black pieces seemed to come to life, jumping up and landing on their own.

While Ning Fuyi was in a daze, Chu Qingqiu had already played several rounds with the black pieces. Her hair fluttered, occasionally covering her eyes before being brushed away by the breeze. When her eyes focused in thought, they were like a quiet, clear lake.

Ning Fuyi didn't realize she was staring at Chu Qingqiu's profile in a daze.

"You lost." Chu Qingqiu said calmly, dropping the last chess piece with decisive efficiency in her movements.

The black piece that had been raised paused, then politely returned to the chess box. The black and white pieces on the board also turned into clear water and merged into the ground. Only then did Chu Qingqiu look up, meeting Ning Fuyi's direct gaze.

Such an intense gaze made Chu Qingqiu uncomfortable. She turned her head away: "What are you looking at?"

"Looking at the Venerable." Ning Fuyi answered honestly, her red lips holding a smile. "How come I never noticed before that the Venerable is so beautiful?"

Chu Qingqiu's hand that was adjusting her clothing stopped in mid-air, staying frozen for a long moment before she put it down: "For cultivators, appearance is merely external."

Ning Fuyi pursed her lips noncommittally and walked to Chu Qingqiu's side. At this moment, the unfinished game was broken, and the water walls on all sides gradually melted away, revealing the starlight outside. They found themselves on shallow waters that sparkled like a bronze mirror, extending in all directions, with magnificent starry skies in the distance moving at speeds unseen in the mortal world.

Such a spectacular Milky Way was rarely seen. Although they knew everything before them was just a burial illusion, they couldn't help but marvel.

Ning Fuyi reached out to pull Chu Qingqiu, who was still sitting on the ground. However, she didn't give her hand and got up by herself. But Ning Fuyi's sharp eyes caught sight of Chu Qingqiu's earlobes turning a clear, tender pink.

Just because she had said she was beautiful? Ning Fuyi had never thought that someone as formidable as Chu Qingqiu would also feel shy from a stranger's compliment.

However, since her rebirth, Chu Qingqiu had already shown too many sides that she normally wouldn't reveal.

"That is the real coffin." Chu Qingqiu suddenly spoke, drawing Ning Fuyi's thoughts away.

In mid-air appeared a huge stone coffin, completely out of place with the surrounding galaxy. Iron chains as thick as wrists hung from each of the coffin's four corners, clattering in the strong wind.

Chu Qingqiu reached out to block Ning Fuyi's retreat, her White Bone weapon already horizontally positioned in front of her, watching the stone coffin swaying in the sudden gale with vigilance.

With a creaking sound, the stone coffin was finally opened, revealing a set of clean white bones draped in spider web-like black robes. Tens of thousands of shooting stars fell from the sky, and for a moment the entire heaven and earth flickled with divine light.

"Is this... Chi Du¹?" Ning Fuyi asked in a low voice.

"Yes." Chu Qingqiu answered, her expression solemn.

"This is not an ordinary corpse. It seems Chi Du built such a tomb to use formations to keep his remaining soul in his bones."

"I thought only mortals wanted immortality. It turns out even gods don't want to die." Ning Fuyi raised her eyebrows.

"Gods and mortals originally have no difference." Chu Qingqiu shook her head. "The love, hate, anger, and delusion they should have are all the same."

"So that impostor went through all this trouble to get us to fall into Chi Du's tomb just to have us break the mechanisms and find Chi Du's divine body?"

As Ning Fuyi spoke, applause suddenly came from behind them. The two turned around together, and the Empress's extremely seductive face appeared from the void.

"Worthy of being Divine Venerable Chu Ling. If not for the Venerable's assistance, I thought I would never be able to enter this damned ancient tomb in this lifetime." The Empress wore a bright red dress, her lower legs and two snow-white arms completely exposed, swaying gracefully with the red dress.

"Who are you? How do you know my name?" Chu Qingqiu faced her with an unchanged expression.

"A drop in the ocean, not worth mentioning, not even half as worthy as the Venerable." The Empress smiled until her eyes curved like crescent moons. She walked barefoot across the water's surface, crystal drops rolling down from her taut instep like magnolia petals covered in dew.

"As for how I know, it's thanks to the Venerable's good disciple." The Empress said softly.

"What do you mean?" Chu Qingqiu asked again, but the Empress no longer answered. She directly passed by the two of them and walked beneath the suspended coffin, looking up with stars reflected in her eyes.

"Chi Du, oh Chi Du, I've searched for you for tens of thousands of years. Now the shackles you hung on my body should finally be returned." She said with curved eyes.

Then she spread her arms wide, and the surroundings became like collapsing mountains and seas. The mirror-like water surface stirred up shocking waves, and the splashing water was higher than the stars. Ning Fuyi quickly covered her face to block the water spray.

Then in the chaos, earth-shattering explosive sounds roared in their ears. The stone coffin split into pieces with sparks flying in the haze. As the bones inside shattered, they burst forth with blood mist that filled the sky, accompanied by mournful divine chanting, falling toward the ground.

Both were shocked to see that the Empress had actually blown Chi Du's divine body and remaining soul to smithereens.

What intense hatred this must be to so recklessly dig up someone's grave!

Chu Qingqiu reached out to summon her immortal power, condensing it into an umbrella above them to block the blood mist that had turned into rain.

The Empress's dress was stained with blood, becoming even more vivid red. She looked up and laughed heartily, letting the blood rain fall on her pale cheeks.

In the mysterious void, something seemed to break. With the sound of a zither string snapping, a crack appeared in the sky. The Empress's figure suddenly collapsed to the ground, as if drained of all strength, no longer moving.

The blood rain continued falling incessantly, like a bursting dam. Both Ning Fuyi and Chu Qingqiu were somewhat confused, but seeing that this tomb was about to collapse, Ning Fuyi couldn't care about anything else and shouted for Xiangsi.

The divine sword suddenly expanded, carrying the two of them up, rushing toward the crack in the sky through the wind and rain.

However, just as they were about to rush out of the tomb, Ning Fuyi's gaze inadvertently swept over what was below and discovered the woman still lying in a pool of blood, her face bearing hatred and the exhilaration of facing death without fear.

A strange feeling suddenly crossed her heart. This strangeness surprised her. She thought her heart had been hardened enough after being forged in her previous life, but somehow, the longer she immersed herself in this life, the more her heart seemed to waver.

Was it because of Chu Qingqiu? Because she had always been by her side, so she hadn't felt hatred for a long time? Those moments filled with deep resentment seemed to have become distant.

Or perhaps the expression on the woman's face below was something she had seen on her own face during those thousand years of the past.

"It seems she doesn't plan to live." Chu Qingqiu's voice sounded in her ear.

"Do you want to save her?"

Ning Fuyi didn't speak, but Xiangsi beneath their feet slowed down considerably. They stood at the edge of the crack, watching the tomb collapse bit by bit.

"But what if I save the wrong person?" Ning Fuyi turned to look at Chu Qingqiu, only to find that she was also looking at her.

"Just do it." Chu Qingqiu said, her voice light as a whisper.

"I'm here."

Footnotes:

¹ **Chi Du (赤都)** - The name of the ancient god whose tomb they are exploring. "Chi" means red/scarlet and "Du" means capital/city, so literally "Red Capital" or "Crimson Capital"